TWO ENGLISH MUGS PODCAST

How to Build an English Sentence

Episode 28 · Full Transcription

Emma & Josh

B1 Intermediate

EMMA: Have you ever tried to tell a really simple story where you know all the English words in your head, but when you open your mouth, you just cannot get them out fast enough?

JOSH: Uh, yeah. I sound like a broken robot just saying, uh, man, dog, rain.

EMMA: Huh. Yes, exactly. It is the absolute worst feeling.

JOSH: But I mean, if I don't try to think of the whole sentence first, won't I just sound like a, you know, little kid reading a picture book?

EMMA: Not at all. And that is exactly why today we are talking about how to build an English sentence block by block.

JOSH: Oh, nice.

EMMA: Yeah, we are going to share some funny stories, learn some really useful words, and show you exactly how to upgrade your everyday sentences. Plus, stick around until the end because we have one special trick to show you where a single word becomes a whole natural answer.

JOSH: I definitely need that.

EMMA: Hello and welcome to Two English Mugs, where we learn English through real everyday conversations. I'm Emma.

JOSH: And I'm Josh.

EMMA: This is a B1 lesson. It is not baby English and it is not too advanced. We explain new words as we go, and the PDF transcript with useful vocabulary words is in the description.

JOSH: Awesome. Let's get into it.

EMMA: So going back to that broken robot feeling, it is a real pain, right?

JOSH: Oh, it's terrible.

EMMA: You want to tell a friend about a cozy movie night you just had, the warm tea, the rain on the window.

JOSH: Right. You have this, like, whole beautiful picture in your head.

EMMA: Exactly. You even know all the words. But the second you try to speak, your brain just misfires.

JOSH: Misfires.

EMMA: Yes. A misfire is when something just does not work the way it is supposed to. You try to speak and your brain just misfires.

JOSH: Huh. Yeah. And out comes a movie good brain, like a telegraph machine from the 1800s.

EMMA: Yes. And the reason this happens is because you are trying to think of the entire giant sentence all at once before you even start speaking.

JOSH: Wait, native speakers don't do that?

EMMA: No, they do not. And that is our first big lesson today. We build sentences. We never think them whole.

JOSH: Really? They don't plan the whole thing out?

EMMA: Never. Native speakers just start with a small piece and build on it.

JOSH: Okay, well, so how do we start doing that without sounding silly?

EMMA: Well, that is exactly the fear, right? We all have this fear of sounding stupid if we do not use big, complicated sentences.

JOSH: Yeah. I mean, in school, my teachers always wanted these huge, long paragraphs in my essays.

EMMA: Mine too. We are taught that long equals smart.

JOSH: Right. If I just say 5 words, I feel like I am failing.

EMMA: But in spoken English, trying to build a huge sentence in your working memory, the workspace in your brain, causes a complete overload.

JOSH: Uh, an overload?

EMMA: Yes. An overload is when there is just too much of something for a system to handle.

JOSH: Ah, got it. Yeah. My brain definitely gets overloaded with all the grammar rules.

EMMA: So the lesson here is incredibly simple. Short sentences are not bad sentences. A short sentence is actually strong and clear.

JOSH: Like, uh, the man found the dog.

EMMA: Exactly. 5 words. It is perfect. You do not need to show off with big words. You just need to be understood.

JOSH: Right. Survival first, showing off second. But, um, how do we actually put these short sentences together when we're stressed out?

EMMA: Well, to do that, we need a totally new way to see language. Instead of a giant web of grammar rules, I want you to picture children's toys.

JOSH: Like, uh, Lego blocks?

EMMA: Yes, Lego blocks are the perfect picture for this. Think about how you build a toy house.

JOSH: You don't try to make the whole house out of one giant piece of plastic.

EMMA: No, you would just take a bunch of little square blocks and snap them together one by one.

JOSH: Right. One piece at a time.

EMMA: And that is exactly how fluent English works. You take one simple block of information, then you snap another simple block onto it.

JOSH: So you just stack small pieces of information?

EMMA: Yes, that is the lesson here. You use a building block picture in your mind. It makes speaking so much less scary.

JOSH: Well, it makes a lot of sense, actually. So what is the very first block we need to pick up?

EMMA: The first block, the foundation of the house, is what we call the core. It is the absolute minimum you need to say to make sense.

JOSH: Okay, so what does this core block look like?

EMMA: It is just 3 things: who does the action, what they do, and what they do it to.

JOSH: Who does what and to what?

EMMA: Exactly. Subject, verb, object. Who does what to what?

JOSH: Oh. So like, um, I drink coffee.

EMMA: Yes. I is the who, drink is what you do, coffee is what you do it to.

JOSH: Or, um, Max chases birds, my neighbor's dog.

EMMA: Yes. Max is the who, chases is the action, birds are the to what.

JOSH: But wait, what if I just say, I sleep? There is no to what there.

EMMA: That is a great catch. There is a small exception for some verbs. I sleep or she runs are complete without the third part, but usually you need all 3.

JOSH: Right. So normally it's the 3 parts.

EMMA: Yes. And when you use that simple 3-part core, your English is flawless.

JOSH: Flawless. That means perfect, right?

EMMA: Yes. Flawless means perfect with absolutely no mistakes.

JOSH: Nice. I like being flawless, but wait, what if I still panic and stumble?

EMMA: Stumble. That is a great word. To stumble means to trip over your words or your feet. And if you do stumble, that brings us to my favorite tool.

JOSH: Oh, what is it? I need all the tools I can get.

EMMA: Let's say you are in a meeting at work. A coworker asks you a question about your weekend and you suddenly feel that panic rising.

JOSH: Oh, I know that panic. You freeze up completely. All the words just disappear.

EMMA: Right. You want to give them a huge detailed answer about your new sofa and the movie you watched, but you can't.

JOSH: Yeah. There's a brain traffic jam.

EMMA: So you use the freeze tool. The lesson is say the core, stop talking, and keep the conversation going.

JOSH: Wait, I just stop talking?

EMMA: Yes. You say, I watched a movie, and then you put a hard period on it.

JOSH: Wow. I watched a movie. Boom. Done.

EMMA: Exactly. You have successfully answered. The silence that follows is not awkward. It is natural.

JOSH: Oh, because then they can just ask, oh, what movie?

EMMA: Yes. It relieves all the pressure. You did not stumble. You stood on solid ground.

JOSH: I love that. Hey, real quick, listener, I want to hear from you.

EMMA: Oh, good idea. Let's do a quick comment check. I will start a line and you, the listener, finish it in the comments below.

JOSH: The line is:

EMMA: This week, one English block I will practice is.

JOSH: Great.

EMMA: This week, one English block I will practice is. Tell us in the comments.

JOSH: So we have our core block. We know how to stop. But I mean, how do we add details later?

EMMA: We need to know how to add more blocks without breaking the house, right? And the most common thing we want to add is when something happened.

JOSH: Right. Like saying last night or every day.

EMMA: Yes. This is our time block, and there is a very strict rule for this block.

JOSH: Uh-oh, a rule.

EMMA: This one is easy. The lesson is time always goes at the end, at the very, very end of your sentence.

JOSH: So if my core is, I watched a movie, I just snap the time block on the end.

EMMA: Exactly. I watched a movie last night, or I drink coffee every morning.

JOSH: I drink coffee every morning. That feels really natural. I don't have to think about it.

EMMA: That is the whole point. By always putting time at the end, you save your brain energy for other things.

JOSH: Okay, so time is at the end. What about where things happen?

EMMA: Ah, the place block. This is things like at home, in the park, or on the balcony.

JOSH: So do I put the place block at the very beginning? Or maybe mix it up.

EMMA: No, this is where people get confused and freeze. The lesson is place goes after the object and before the time.

JOSH: Wait, run that by me again.

EMMA: Think of a factory assembly line.

JOSH: Okay, an assembly line.

EMMA: Place goes directly after your core block, but before your time block. Let's look at a story. My neighbor Josh—

JOSH: Hey, that's me.

EMMA: Yes. Josh walks his dog Max. That is the core. Where does he walk him?

JOSH: In the park.

EMMA: And when does he do it?

JOSH: Every evening.

EMMA: So put it all on the assembly line.

JOSH: Oh, so it's Josh walks Max in the park every evening.

EMMA: Spot on. You built it perfectly. Core, place, time. Who does what, where, when.

JOSH: Let me try another one. I Water my plants on the balcony every morning. Wow. That is a really long, good sentence.

EMMA: Yes. And you built it without any stress because you didn't have to make any decisions.

JOSH: It just snaps together. But what if I want to tell a real story? Not just facts, but like a full story.

EMMA: Right. Because humans do not just list facts like a robot. We want to explain why things happen. We want to complain about our day.

JOSH: I definitely like to complain. I wanted to sleep, but Max woke me up at 6.

EMMA: Yes. And you just used our 4th block perfectly, the connect block.

JOSH: I did. What was it?

EMMA: But long stories are just an illusion.

JOSH: An illusion?

EMMA: Yes.

JOSH: Really?

EMMA: The lesson here is to make a long story Just build 2 short sentences and connect them with basic words like because, so, but, and, and.

JOSH: Oh, wow. So I don't need fancy grammar to tell a long story. Native speakers really just do that?

EMMA: They really do. Nobody thinks in long sentences. Think of the connector word like a hinge.

JOSH: Uh, a hinge?

EMMA: Exactly.

JOSH: Like on a door?

EMMA: Exactly. A hinge is the small metal piece that joins 2 heavy doors together so they can swing.

JOSH: Oh, I see.

EMMA: I forgot my umbrella is one block. I got wet is another block. The hinge is so.

JOSH: I forgot my umbrella, so I got wet.

EMMA: I like cooking, but I don't like washing dishes. Huh, see? It really is just 2 small blocks snapped together with a hinge.

JOSH: It really is. And it makes you sound incredibly fluent.

EMMA: It does. Now let's prove it with our final challenge.

JOSH: Okay, let's do it.

EMMA: So at the start of the episode, I promised you a trick where a single word becomes a whole natural answer.

JOSH: Yeah, the one-word challenge. How does that work?

EMMA: I'm going to give you one prompt word, and you are going to use the 4 blocks to build a huge natural answer step by step.

JOSH: Okay, I am ready. Give me the word.

EMMA: The word is weekend. Imagine a coworker asks, how was your weekend? Do not panic. Just give me a core block.

JOSH: Uh, okay. Core block: I visited my parents.

EMMA: Perfect core. Now add a time block. Remember where it goes.

JOSH: Time goes at the very end. So, last Sunday.

EMMA: Good. Now add a place block. Where does it go on the assembly line?

JOSH: After the core, before the time. So, at their house. That makes I visited my parents at their house last Sunday.

EMMA: Brilliant. Now add a hinge, a connector, and give me a reason with another short sentence.

JOSH: Uh, because it was my dad's birthday. So the whole thing is, I visited my parents at their house last Sunday because it was my dad's birthday.

EMMA: Listen to that. It is amazing. The lesson is, if you trust the blocks, one word really does become a whole fluent answer.

JOSH: Wow. Let's do one more. I like this.

EMMA: Okay. The word is book.

JOSH: Core. I read a new book. Place. In my living room. So I read a new book in my living room.

EMMA: Keep going.

JOSH: Time. Last weekend. I read a new book in my living room last weekend.

EMMA: Now the hinge.

JOSH: Because my friend told me it was good. So I read a new book in my living room last weekend because my friend told me it was good.

EMMA: Flawless.

JOSH: Flawless.

EMMA: And it fixes that terrible man-dog-rain problem from the beginning, too.

JOSH: Oh yeah. How would we fix that one?

EMMA: Just use the blocks. A man lost his dog in the rain. That's a core and a place.

JOSH: He looked for the dog all night. Core and time.

EMMA: He found the dog under a bridge because the dog was hiding from the storm. Core, place, hinge, core.

JOSH: That is a real story, and I didn't need any new words. If I don't use the blocks, I just ramble on and on and confuse everyone.

EMMA: Ramble. That is a great word to end on. And actually, let us wind things down with vocab unwind.

JOSH: Oh, sweet.

EMMA: We had some great words today. Word number 1 is misfire. Repeat after me. Misfire.

JOSH: Misfire.

EMMA: A misfire is when something does not work the way it is supposed to, like an engine or your brain when you freeze.

JOSH: Yeah, my brain misfires when I try to speak too fast.

EMMA: Exactly. Word number 2 is overload. Repeat after me, overload.

JOSH: Overload.

EMMA: An overload is when there is just too much of something for a system to handle.

JOSH: Like when I try to remember too many grammar rules at once. Total overload.

EMMA: Yes. Word number 3 is flawless. Repeat after me: flawless.

JOSH: Flawless.

EMMA: Flawless means perfect, with absolutely no mistakes.

JOSH: Like a short, simple 3-word sentence. Flawless.

EMMA: Yes. Word number 4 is stumble. Repeat after me: stumble.

JOSH: Stumble.

EMMA: To stumble means to trip over your words or your feet.

JOSH: I stumble a lot when I don't use the free tool.

EMMA: Me too. Word number 5 is hinge. Repeat after me: hinge.

JOSH: Hinge.

EMMA: A hinge is the piece that joins 2 things together, like the word because joining 2 sentences.

JOSH: It's the little connector piece. Hinge.

EMMA: And finally, word number 6 is ramble. Repeat after me: ramble.

JOSH: Ramble.

EMMA: To ramble means to talk for a long time without a clear point.

JOSH: Like that one guy in every business meeting who just rambles for 10 minutes.

EMMA: Exactly. Before we go, let's do a silent listening check. Just score yourself in your head right now. Did you understand 50%, 70%, or nearly all of today's conversation?

JOSH: Hopefully nearly all of it.

EMMA: Awesome. Let's do a quick recap. Point 1, build your core block. Who does what? And to what?

JOSH: Right? The foundation.

EMMA: Point 2, add context. Place goes first. Time goes at the very end.

JOSH: The assembly line.

EMMA: Point 3, connect your short sentences with simple hinges like because, so, but, and and. Thank you so much for listening today, and please take care of your family.

JOSH: Make sure to like the episode and, uh, come back next week for more.

EMMA: Start short, add one thing, and connect. Bye everyone.

Vocab Unwind

6 key words and phrases from this episode

#	WORD	MEANING	ANALOGY	EXAMPLE
1	**misfire**	When something does not work the way it is supposed to, like an engine or your brain when you freeze.	An old car that coughs and will not start.	*My brain misfires when I try to speak too fast.*
2	**overload**	When there is just too much of something for a system to handle.	Ten tabs open at once on a slow laptop.	*Like when I try to remember too many grammar rules at once. Total overload.*
3	**flawless**	Perfect, with absolutely no mistakes.	A wall where every brick sits perfectly straight.	*Like a short, simple 3-word sentence. Flawless.*
4	**stumble**	To trip over your words or your feet.	A small trip on a flat pavement.	*I stumble a lot when I don't use the free tool.*
5	**hinge**	The piece that joins two things together, like the word because joining two sentences.	The little metal joint that lets a door swing.	*It's the little connector piece. Hinge.*
6	**ramble**	To talk for a long time without a clear point.	A road with no destination.	*Like that one guy in every business meeting who just rambles for 10 minutes.*